



“I have never seen such a flood in my life. Our entire village has been submerged.”

SULOCHANA DEVI, 27

Housewife, Kaup

It was a difficult trek for this mother of two. “Since the past one week, we were dithering over whether to leave our home or not. But this morning when somebody told us that the link road to Saharsa was getting eroded, we decided it was time. I have never seen such a flood in my lifetime,” she said. There was the growing threat of Kaup, the village she lived in, being cut off from the main Saur Bajar-Pathalghat road. “So then,” as Devi says, “we collected our valuables, locked the house and decided to trek to our relatives’ house in Saharsa.” Devi is not sure if her house would survive the onslaught. The crops were certain to be damaged. Her husband Nishikant looked beaten as he carried one of the children. Kaup emptied out in a matter of hours and headed to safer grounds. Already 113 villages are under flood waters in Saharsa and around 62,000 families have been severely affected in the area.

lence, work was stopped. The Indian mission got in touch with the local administration at Sunsari seeking security for its team, which was not provided. Then when the material for repair, including boulders, was sent from India it was detained by customs even though the agreement between the two countries clearly states that India is within its right to send in such material.

By then the river had begun eroding the barrage at the rate of 25 m a day. Within 11 days it cut the spurs by 270 m and created a 1km gap in the embankment. Yet the August 17 bulletin of the Irrigation and Flood Control Department claimed that all the embankments in the state were safe. On the same day, Satyanarayana had been demoted and transferred from Birpur, seemingly because of an earlier enquiry unrelated to the floods. Between August 5, when the erosion started, and August 18, when river breached the bund, the Government had close to a fortnight to warn the people and evacuate the villagers. During this period the Bihar administration could have geared up for a massive rescue effort by moving men and materials and organising for boats. However, it was only on August 18, the day the breach occurred, that the Government sent an sos to the Nepal Government to provide security for Bihar’s engineers and contractors to carry on repair. By then it was too late.

Chief Minister Nitish Kumar was told of the

Project Chief Engineer, E. Satyanarayana, posted at Birpur, sent a series of frantic warning messages about the impending danger to project Liaison Officer Arun Kumar Singh posted in Kathmandu, asking him to initiate action. He also sent messages to his superiors in Patna. Singh was on leave and the messages went unattended. But the Irrigation Department in Patna is believed to have sent a team of its contractors to carry out repairs at the barrage a week later. It is not clear whether they were sent for routine maintenance or were reacting to Satyanarayana’s messages, but they seemed to have run into trouble with the locals. The contractor then complained to the commercial counsellor of the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu. Apparently, a month ago the contractor had a dispute with the Maoist-led Young Communist League that led to the workers demanding higher wages and following some vio-